



2022 Texas Prekindergarten Guidelines

PK3 and PK4 Comprehensive Guide



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I. Social and Emotional Development Domain

While a prekindergarten education should include activities that strengthen cognitive skills, it must also provide for the development of the social and emotional competencies required for school readiness and success in life. The development of these personal and social skills enables children to build a sense of who they are and what they can do. Supportive, positive relationships between teachers and children are essential to implementing effective practices that support a child's social and emotional development. Children must establish positive relationships with adults and peers to participate effectively in the classroom community, assert independence in appropriate ways, and accomplish tasks that are meaningful to them without infringing on the rights of others. Children who can follow directions, communicate their wants, and needs effectively, and get along with other children are better prepared for kindergarten and beyond.

Early experiences influence brain development by establishing the neural connections that provide the foundation for language, reasoning, problem solving, social skills, behavior, and emotional health. Daily experiences such as transitioning from home to school, sharing a space or materials, resolving conflicts, and demonstrating empathy contribute to a child's social and emotional development. However, children benefit from direct instruction and repeated opportunities to practice these skills.

The Social and Emotional Development Domain of the *Texas Prekindergarten Guidelines* is divided into the following skills: self-concept, self-regulation, relationships with others, and social awareness.

A. Self-Concept

Central to understanding emotional development is the idea of self-concept: an ever-increasing level of conscious awareness of one's feelings, thoughts, abilities, likes, and dislikes, as well as awareness of one's body in space. Prekindergarten children's emerging ability to perceive these aspects of themselves at a conscious level distinguishes them from toddlers, who lack such awareness. Children begin to generate multiple answers to the question "Who am I?" which is an essential aspect of becoming competent in related areas, such as self-control and social/friendship skills. A child's identity includes cultural and linguistic factors, and the prekindergarten environment is one of the first public opportunities for children to recognize the uniqueness of their own home culture and language as well as accept and value cultures and languages different from their own. Early childhood educators must model the mindset of diversity as an asset in the classroom, school, and community.

PK3 Outcome	PK4 Outcome
PK3.I.A.1 Child is building competence in controlling own body movements.	PK4.I.A.1 Child is aware of where own body is in space and respects personal boundaries.

I. Social and Emotional Development Domain



Child Behaviors

The child may:

- stay in designated personal spaces without intruding upon others (e.g., stays in own seat at lunch table without kicking feet or leaning against neighboring children or stays seated on assigned space during whole group instruction without distracting others)
- move around the classroom without stepping on materials or disrupting others' activities
- maintain appropriate personal space when speaking with others

PK3 Outcome	PK4 Outcome
PK3.I.A.2 Child can identify own physical attributes and indicate some likes and dislikes when prompted.	PK4.I.A.2 Child shows self-awareness of physical attributes, personal preferences, and own abilities.

Child Behaviors

The child may:

- use basic physical characteristics to describe self (e.g., hair color, eye color, or height)
- identify with a group or groups to which they belong (e.g., race/ethnicity, speaker of another language, family member, classroom group)
- use personal inclinations to describe self (e.g., favorite color, food, or game)
- use specific competencies to describe self (e.g., "I can tie my shoes." or "I am good at drawing.")

PK3 Outcome	PK4 Outcome
PK3.I.A.3 Child begins to show awareness of own abilities.	PK4.I.A.3 Child shows reasonable opinion of his own abilities and limitations.

Child Behaviors

The child may:

- choose to use the stairs instead of the climbing rope on the playground
- request help from adults when appropriate
- decline help politely when not needed (e.g., "No thanks, I can do it myself.")

I. Social and Emotional Development Domain



PK3 Outcome	PK4 Outcome
PK3.I.A.4 Child shows initiative in trying new activities but may not persist when obstacles or challenges arise.	PK4.I.A.4 Child shows initiative in trying new activities and demonstrates perseverance when attempting to overcome obstacles or challenges.

Child Behaviors

The child may:

- independently select a new book or game in a learning center
- work on a puzzle until it is complete
- try several strategies to solve a problem before seeking adult assistance (e.g., when a crayon breaks, the child replaces the broken crayon with a new crayon instead of raising their hand to tell the teacher)

B. Self-Regulation

Prekindergarten children feel safer and function more successfully in the classroom when rules and routines are consistently implemented. A well-organized classroom with well-prepared activities helps children expand their attention span and build self-control and personal responsibility. As they encounter and overcome new and various social obstacles when interacting with peers, guidance from teachers will enable them to learn acceptable ways of dealing with social and emotional stress and/or excitement.

Self-regulation skills include three subskills: behavior control, emotional control, and control of attention. Subskills only appear in this section of the Texas Prekindergarten Guidelines and are represented by a lowercase letter at the end of the citation.

1. Behavior Control

PK3 Outcome	PK4 Outcome
PK3.I.B.1.a Child follows simple rules and routines when assisted by adults.	PK4.I.B.1.a Child follows classroom rules and routines with occasional reminders from adults.

Child Behaviors

The child may:

- demonstrate understanding of classroom rules
- respond appropriately to classroom behavior expectations

I. Social and Emotional Development Domain



- identify and follow the sequence of the day's events, (e.g., "After centers, it's time to go outside.")
- participate in daily transitions when changing centers, moving from whole group to small group instruction, getting in line, etc.

PK3 Outcome	PK4 Outcome
PK3.I.B.1.b Child takes care of and manages classroom materials with adult assistance.	PK4.I.B.1.b Child takes care of and manages classroom materials.

Child Behaviors

The child may:

- appropriately handle materials during activities
- clean up and place classroom materials in appropriately labeled spaces
- put away personal belongings in their designated space

PK3 Outcome	PK4 Outcome
PK3.I.B.1.c Child manages own behavior with adult guidance and assistance.	PK4.I.B.1.c Child regulates own behavior with occasional reminders or assistance from adults.

Child Behaviors

The child may:

- communicate appropriately to make needs known
- wait for a turn (e.g., waits patiently at the water fountain for a classmate to finish drinking or selects another learning center when the learning center of choice is full)
- refrain from impulsive responses (e.g., waits for turn to be called on during group discussion or requests materials rather than grabbing them)

2. Emotional Control

PK3 Outcome	PK4 Outcome
PK3.I.B.2.a Child recognizes and expresses a range of emotions.	PK4.I.B.2.a Child begins to understand the connection between emotions and behaviors.

I. Social and Emotional Development Domain



Child Behaviors

The child may:

- express feelings or respond with appropriate behavior (e.g., Child does not grab a toy back from a friend, but rather says, “I feel sad when you take my toy!”)
- verbalize understanding that all feelings are okay even though some behaviors may not be okay
- identify appropriate and inappropriate behaviors to common feelings

PK3 Outcome	PK4 Outcome
PK3.I.B.2.b Child is familiar with basic feeling words (e.g., happy, sad, mad, scared).	PK4.I.B.2.b Child uses verbal and nonverbal communication to communicate basic emotions and feelings.

Child Behaviors

The child may:

- demonstrate familiarity with a variety of feeling words (e.g., happy, sad, mad, scared, proud, worried, excited)
- label own feelings when prompted
- identify feelings of characters in stories or movies

PK3 Outcome	PK4 Outcome
PK3.I.B.2.c Child manages intensity of emotions with adult assistance.	PK4.I.B.2.c Child is able to manage intensity of emotions more consistently, although adult guidance is sometimes necessary.

Child Behaviors

The child may:

- use appropriate strategies to decrease level of distress (e.g., requests help when feeling frustrated with a task or seeks comfort from teacher when feeling sad)
- respond positively to adult guidance in using calming strategies (e.g., suggestions to separate self from frustrating situations or take a deep breath)
- show enjoyment while participating in activities that stimulate different types of emotions (e.g., playground games or music activities that require alternation of loud/quiet, fast/slow)



VI. Science Domain

Young children often think that events simply happen without a specific cause or effect. To mature past this developmental stage, prekindergarten children need exposure to inquiry-based science, which gives them the opportunity to explore and to make sense of their world with adult guidance. This allows children to be curious about the environment in which they live, ask a lot of questions, make observations, describe what they experience using their five senses, and make tentative explanations that can be shared with others. Children’s curiosity creates a natural desire to watch, explore, question, and understand the world around them.

Science concepts for prekindergarten children should be developmentally appropriate, interesting, and engaging, and able to be studied from multiple perspectives, in depth, and over time. When children have many and varied opportunities to explore a concept, they come to the final stage of scientific inquiry with a rich set of experiences to which they base their reflections and their developing theories. Although children can easily learn science as they observe and interact daily, it is the teacher’s role to provide a learning environment that offers discovery and exploration through hands-on opportunities. These opportunities are particularly helpful for multilingual learners who may not be able to explain what they know or have learned in a second language. Children should be encouraged to be curious, ask questions, work collaboratively, plan investigations, record their observations, and discuss their findings. In addition, science provides a unique context for developing vocabulary, literacy, and math skills and concepts.

The Science domain of the *Texas Prekindergarten Guidelines* is divided into the following skills: physical science, life science, and earth and space science.

A. Physical Science

Prekindergarten children begin to explore properties of materials, positions, and motion of objects through investigations. These explorations using the senses continue as children use attributes to classify and sort objects, make observations and predictions, problem solve, question, and compare. Children learn about sources of energy by investigating and discussing light, heat, electricity, and magnetism. This builds an early understanding of life science, physical science, earth science and chemistry. Processes such as observing and recording data, posing questions, predicting, investigating, and drawing conclusions can provide experiences to support literacy, math, and the sciences.

PK3 Outcome	PK4 Outcome
<i>No PK3 outcomes for this domain of learning.</i>	PK4.VI.A.1 Child observes, investigates, describes, and discusses characteristics of common objects.



Child Behaviors

The child may:

- explore using his senses and uses sensory language to describe characteristics of natural and human-made objects and materials (e.g., wood, cotton, fur, stone, leather, plastic, paper, foil, ingredients for cooking, feathers, sponges)
- sort, group, or classify objects in meaningful ways based on one or more characteristics (e.g., hard/soft or heavy/light; materials that are made of wood, plastic, rock)
- investigate and predict what common objects will do in response to an action (e.g., whether materials will sink/float or melt/freeze)

PK3 Outcome	PK4 Outcome
<i>No PK3 outcomes for this domain of learning.</i>	PK4.VI.A.2 Child observes, investigates, describes, and discusses position and motion of objects.

Child Behaviors

The child may:

- observe, measure, describe, and demonstrate the numerous ways objects can move (e.g., straight, zigzag, round and round, fast, slow)
- use positional language to inform others of the location, arrangement and/or stance of an object (e.g., the books are *under* the table, my folder is *inside* my bag, you are *in front* of me on the carpet, the car is *beside* the track, the ball is *near* the court etc.)
- investigate, predict, and state conclusions regarding how an object moves under a variety of conditions (e.g., “The car won’t roll on the carpet,” “These wheels are bigger; it will go faster.”)

PK3 Outcome	PK4 Outcome
<i>No PK3 outcomes for this domain of learning.</i>	PK4.VI.A.3 Child uses simple scientific tools to learn about objects.

Child Behaviors

The child may:

- know the function of specific tools (e.g., a thermometer measures temperature)
- explore objects by appropriately using magnets, balances, eyedroppers, beakers/jars, etc.
- use a magnifying glass to observe, describe, and discuss the features of a common object (e.g., texture, color, shape, etc.)



PK3 Outcome	PK4 Outcome
<i>No PK3 outcomes for this domain of learning.</i>	PK4.VI.A.4 Child observes, investigates, describes, and discusses sources of energy including light, heat, and electricity.

Child Behaviors

The child may:

- describe common sources of energy (e.g., sun, wind, water)
- demonstrate understanding that some items/equipment must have a source of energy to function (e.g., “Teacher, we need a new battery for this toy.” or “It’s not working; it is not plugged in.”)
- identify common objects in the classroom or their home that need a source of energy to function

B. Life Science

Young children have a keen interest in studying living things, including the unique features of plants and animals, the environments in which they live, and what each living thing needs to thrive. Effective teachers provide opportunities for children to explore, observe, and investigate various organisms through hands-on experiences. Through these experiences, children are encouraged to use newly acquired vocabulary to describe and discuss their observations.

PK3 Outcome	PK4 Outcome
<i>No PK3 outcomes for this domain of learning.</i>	PK4.VI.B.1 Child observes, investigates, describes, and discusses the characteristics of organisms.

Child Behaviors

The child may:

- describe the color, size, and shape of organisms
- describe an organism’s need for food, water, air, light, and shelter
- compare differences and similarities of animals and plants (e.g., fish live in water, all birds have feathers, we can eat some plants)